

"Undone"

Performance & Production Guide

Key of E | 4/4 Time | Mid-Tempo (~92-100 BPM recommended)

Prepared for Jeffrey Bickish

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1. Tempo & Arrangement Strategy

Recommended: Mid-tempo (~92-100 BPM) as the primary release.

Why mid-tempo works best as the lead:

The lyric has a narrative arc (walls up > breakthrough > transformation) that benefits from forward momentum. A mid-tempo pulse keeps the pauses between lines feeling intentional rather than empty. The folk-acoustic genre gives you natural warmth without needing to slow down to achieve intimacy. At ~96 BPM, the spaces between lines become dramatic beats, not dead air.

Slow acoustic version as a follow-up:

Great instinct. A stripped-back version at ~72 BPM released 4-8 weeks later gives you two pieces of content from one song. Label it something like 'Undone (Acoustic)' or 'Undone (Bare)'. This version works beautifully as a live-session YouTube video, just you and the guitar in a natural setting around Sandpoint.

Light piano intro suggestion:

Yes, open with a 4-bar piano motif (the chorus riff played gently, single notes or arpeggiated) before the guitar enters. This gives listeners a melodic hook immediately and creates a bookend when it returns full-force in the chorus. Keep it simple: just the right hand, no chords, almost like a music-box quality.

2. Vowel Modification Map

Vowel modification helps you maintain tone quality, projection, and emotional color across your range. Below are the key moments in each section where shaping the vowel intentionally will make a difference. Focus on these during practice; they'll become second nature in performance.

Verse 1

Lyric	Vowel Target	Why
"So many times"	"tahh-eemz" - open the "i" in times toward "ah"	Opens your chest voice on the first phrase; sets a warm tone
"chasing illusion"	"ill-OO-zhun" - round the "oo" fully	The word "illusion" is the emotional pivot; rounding gives it weight
"Pain buried deep"	"Peh-n" not "Pay-n" - keep "ai" narrow	Prevents nasality; keeps the vulnerability raw
"locked up away"	"uh-WAY" - open the second syllable wide	Creates a sense of space in the word, matching the meaning
"any intrusion"	"in-TROO-zhun" - same rounding as "illusion"	Rhyme consistency; matching vowel shapes locks in the couplet

Pre-Chorus

Lyric	Vowel Target	Why
"But you broke through"	"brOHk" - keep the "o" tall and round, not flat	This is a breakthrough moment; the vowel should feel like it's opening up
"walls came down"	"dahh-wn" - drop the jaw on "down"	Physically opens your sound for the big emotional release
"lonely heart you found"	"fahh-wnd" - open the "ou" toward "ah"	Warmth and resonance on the landing note

Chorus

Lyric	Vowel Target	Why
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"undone by beauty"	"uhn-DUHN" - keep "u" short and centered; "BYOO-tee" - bright "ee"	The contrast between the dark "uh" and bright "ee" mirrors the lyric's tension
"awe and wonder"	"AWW" - drop jaw fully; "WUHN-der" - don't close the "u"	This is your biggest emotional word; give it all the space
"transformed by your love"	"trans-FORMD" - round the "or"; "luhv" - keep short	The "or" resonates in your mask; "love" lands soft
"easy to trust"	"EE-zee" bright; "truhst" - quick release	Brightness here conveys joy and surrender
"Here I am undone"	"HEER ah-ahm uhn-DUHN" open every vowel wide	Final statement; give each word full resonance

Verse 2

Lyric	Vowel Target	Why
"see through my disguise"	"dis-GAHZ" - open the "i" in "guise" toward "ah"	Same technique as "times" in V1; consistency across verses
"no one could enter"	"EHN-ter" - keep it forward and bright	Clarity on the consonants here matters for storytelling
"innocence had died"	"IHN-oh-sehns" - three clear syllables; "dahd" for "died"	Don't swallow the word; let each syllable land
"fear my inner tormenter"	"tor-MEHN-ter" - forward placement, don't darken the "e"	Keeps the word cutting through the mix even as emotion builds

3. Live Performance Expressions

These are suggestions for storytelling through physicality. The goal is not choreography but authentic gestures that emerge from the emotion. Practice them enough that they feel natural, not rehearsed. Less is more in folk; one deliberate gesture beats five busy ones.

Verse 1 - The Guarded Man

Body: Start slightly closed. Shoulders subtly inward, eyes down or half-closed. You're telling a story about being shut off; your body should reflect that.

"So many times, I tried" - Slight head shake on "so many," like you're looking back with tired recognition. Eyes can drift to a middle-distance point (not the audience yet).

"Pain buried deep inside" - Free hand can come to your chest briefly, not dramatically. Just a touch. Let your face show the weight: furrowed brow, slight tension in the jaw.

"locked up away from any intrusion" - Subtle closing gesture with the free hand (fingers curling inward or hand turning palm-down). This is the "door closed" moment.

Pre-Chorus - The Breakthrough

Body: This is the pivot. Your physicality should begin opening.

"But you broke through" - Eyes come up to the audience for the first time. This is powerful; you've been inward and now you're making contact. Let your eyebrows lift slightly, a look of surprise/wonder.

"the walls came down" - Free hand opens, palm up, or moves outward from your body. Small gesture, big impact. Face softens from the tension of the verse.

"This lost boy's lonely heart you found" - Gentle smile beginning. Hand can come back to chest on "heart" but open this time, not guarded.

Chorus - Surrender

Body: Open, vulnerable, present. This is where you give yourself to the audience.

"Now here I am, undone by beauty" - Arms/hand open slightly wider. The word "undone" deserves a slight upward look or closed eyes, like you're letting something wash over you.

"Just a man, in awe and wonder" - Genuine awe expression: slightly parted lips before singing, wide eyes. Let the wonder show on your face before the words come out.

"And I, I'm transformed" - Stand a little taller here. Subtle but the audience will feel it. You've changed.

"So here I am, Here I am undone" - Full eye contact with the audience. Both arms can be slightly open (guitar permitting). This is the "take me as I am" moment.

Verse 2 - Deeper Revelation

Body: More open than V1 but with moments of returning tension.

"You see through my disguise" - A knowing, almost rueful half-smile. Eyes narrow slightly, like you're acknowledging being caught.

"Thought innocence had died" - This is heavy. Let your face go still. A pause in expression is its own expression. Don't oversell it.

"crippled by fear my inner tormenter" - Brief tension returns: jaw sets, eyes intensify. Then release it going into the pre-chorus.

Outro - Resolution

"So here I am, undone by beauty" - Quieter delivery, almost conversational. Lean slightly toward the mic/audience.

"Just a man" (vocalize) - Close your eyes. This is the most intimate moment. The vocalization without words says "I have no more words for this."

"Here I am...undone" (abrupt cut) - Eyes open on "undone," direct eye contact with one person in the audience if possible. Hold the silence after the cut for 2-3 full seconds before breaking character. That silence is part of the song.

4. Vocal Embellishments & Runs

Keeping these folk-authentic: tasteful 2-4 note ornaments that add emotion without pulling focus from the lyric. Think of these as sighs, catches, and releases rather than technical displays.

Recommended Spots

Location	Lyric	Embellishment	Feel
V1, line 2	"illusion"	Gentle downward slide on "-sion" (2 notes: start a whole step above, fall into the target note)	Like a sigh; the illusion fading away
Pre-Chorus	"found"	3-note turn: target note > half step up > back to target. Quick and warm.	Joy and relief in being discovered
Chorus 1	"undone" (first time)	Slight scoop up into "un-" from a half step below	Vulnerability; reaching for the word
Chorus 1	"wonder"	Let "-der" drop a third and fade, almost spoken	Awe trailing off into silence
Chorus 2	"transformed"	Hold and add gentle vibrato, then a 2-note descent on "-formed"	Weight of the transformation landing
Vocalization section	Between C2 and Pre-C	Pentatonic phrase: E-G#-A-B-G#-E descending. Keep it breathy and unforced.	Wordless processing; the soul speaking
Outro	"undone" (final)	NO embellishment. Straight tone, clean cut.	Raw honesty; nothing to hide behind

General rule: Embellish more in the second chorus than the first. Keep V1 almost completely straight to establish authenticity. The contrast makes the later ornaments feel earned.

5. Instrumentation & Mix Guide

Song Structure & Build

Section	Instrumentation	Mix Notes
Intro (4-8 bars)	Light piano riff only (single notes, right hand)	Reverb-heavy, placed slightly back in the mix. Almost like a memory. Subtle room sound.
Verse 1	Acoustic guitar + vocal only	Guitar: warm, slightly rolled-off highs. Fingerpick or gentle strum. Vocal: dry-ish, intimate, close-mic feel. Light room reverb only.
Pre-Chorus 1	Acoustic guitar + vocal. Optional: very subtle pad fading in underneath	If using a pad, keep it barely audible. It should be felt not heard. This is the transition from isolation to connection.
Chorus 1	Acoustic guitar + vocal + piano riff (full, both hands now) + light reverb wash	Piano: forward in the mix, this is the hook. Vocal: open up the reverb slightly, give it more space. Guitar can shift to strumming.
Verse 2	Acoustic guitar + vocal + bass (enters here) + piano chording (background)	Bass: simple root notes, warm and round, sit it under everything. Piano: pad-like chords, not the riff. Guitar continues fingerpick pattern.
Pre-Chorus 2	Full band continuing. Optional: add light percussion (shaker or soft kick)	Build energy subtly. If adding percussion, keep it organic and quiet.
Chorus 2	Full arrangement. Piano riff prominent + bass + guitar strumming + optional harmonies	This should feel bigger than Chorus 1. Add a vocal double or harmony on "undone by beauty." More reverb tail.
Vocalization / Bridge	Strip back slightly. Piano arpeggios + bass + light guitar	Create space for the vocal melisma. Less is more here. Let the voice carry.
Pre-Chorus 3	Rebuild: all instruments	This is the final climb. Everything should feel like it's leaning forward.

Outro	Start full, then instruments drop out one by one. Final "undone" = voice only or voice + single piano note	The abrupt cut needs silence after it. No reverb tail on the final word. Dead stop. Let the room do the work.
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Home Studio Recording Tips (Key of E, Your Setup)

Acoustic Guitar:

Record with your condenser mic pointed at the 12th fret, about 8-10 inches back. This captures a balanced tone (not too boomy from the sound hole, not too thin from the neck). In E major, your open strings will ring beautifully; use that. Consider recording two takes and panning them slightly left/right (70/30) for width in the chorus.

Vocals:

Record 6-8 inches from your condenser mic with a pop filter. For V1, sing slightly off-axis (turned 10-15 degrees) for a more intimate, less 'produced' sound. For choruses, sing directly on-axis for full presence. Record a vocal double for Chorus 2 only; keep it 3-4 dB below the lead and panned slightly off-center.

Piano:

If using a digital piano/keyboard through your Focusrite, choose a warm grand piano patch (not bright). For the intro riff, add a touch of built-in reverb from your DAW (plate reverb, ~1.5 sec decay). For the background chording in V2, roll off frequencies above 8kHz to keep it from competing with the vocal.

Bass:

If recording bass guitar through the Focusrite, DI is fine. Keep the part simple: root notes on beats 1 and 3 in the verses, allow slightly more movement in the choruses (walking between the I-IV-V). If using a virtual bass instrument, avoid anything too synthetic; look for an upright bass or warm P-bass sound.

Mix Balance Guide

Element	Level (relative)	Pan	Key Processing
Lead Vocal	0 dB (reference)	Center	Light compression (3:1), de-esser, plate reverb
Acoustic Guitar	-3 to -5 dB	Slight L (10-20%) or stereo pair	High-pass at 80Hz, light compression
Piano (riff)	-4 to -6 dB	Slight R (15-25%)	High-pass at 100Hz, room reverb to match guitar
Piano (chords)	-8 to -10 dB	Wide (30% L/R)	High-pass at 120Hz, roll off above 8kHz
Bass	-6 to -8 dB	Center	Compression (4:1), high-pass at 40Hz
Vocal Double	-6 to -8 dB	Slight L or R (10%)	Match lead processing, slightly more reverb

The Abrupt Ending:

For the final "Here I am...undone" cut, automate all reverb sends to zero on that last word. You want the voice to just stop, with no tail. In your DAW, put a hard fade/cut right at the end of "undone." Leave 2-3

seconds of silence before the track ends. This hanging resolution is your signature moment; the silence IS the final note.